son. With sparse dialogue, Rio lets the tattooed face of his protagonist build tension alongside the silence and ambient sounds of the forest. "I tried my best to remain as neutral as possible because I wanted all my characters and conflicts to have depth," says Rio. "By doing that, you don't become a propaganda film or one with an agenda. There is a sense of discovery about different perspectives."

TO BUILD A VILLAGE

The making of *Angh* is worthy of a documentary in itself. With the local Naga film industry still nascent, Rio and his casting director, Bendang Walling, had their work cut out to find actors. Few would turn up for auditions and the talent pool got smaller when it came to finding Konyak actors in Mon district. Rio ultimately turned to YouTube to find stand-up comedians and, with Anghlong, found his village chief. "He was younger than what I wanted, but his presence, timing, deadpan delivery and body language hooked me immediately," says Rio. For the part of his son, Rio turned to teenager Sobino Rengma, who had lived close to his house. "He is an extremely shy and quiet boy, but very intelligent," says Rio. "He is instinctive and listens very well." In fact, barring Scottish actor Douglas Henshall, who plays the 'white ghost' a.k.a. the story's American Baptist missionary, none of the cast had set foot on a film set before.

To nail the visual palette, Rio roped in two of his batchmates from NFTS. Portuguese production designer Margarida Caetano Dias visited Nagaland twice, going to villages and houses in Mon district. Since today's villages are too gentrified to stand in for the film's early 1960s setting, she built the set of an abandoned village with the help of the Konyak community. "It was wonderful to see them collect the material from the forest and practise rituals," says Rio.

NFTS alumna cinematographer Adam Pietkiewicz came on board to shoot the movie on 16mm film, which was ideal to recreate the texture of archival footage and pictures of American missionaries and the Konyak people from the early 20th century. Apart from his research, Rio felt it imperative to involve the Konyak Literature Board and Konyak Union, right from script development. "These cultures are so nuanced and complex that reading isn't enough," adds Rio. "We'd have been clueless without their involvement."

As invites from international film festivals pour in and the Oscar campaign gathers speed, Nancy and Theja are eagerly looking forward to the release in India and, more so, to share the film with people in Nagaland. With only two cinemas, both in Dimapur, the duo knows their mission is herculean, but well worth it. "It will be back to the old days of a man on the bicycle with a projector and sound system travelling to towns and villages," Nancy says. "It is important for us to share the film with the community by taking it to every nook and corner of Nagaland."

More than anything, Nancy hopes that Theja on the world stage propels others to pursue their dream. Says Nancy, "I'd tell filmmakers, don't be conscious or scared of where you come from. You could be from a small state like ours, but you can reach a global platform." Sometimes, it may even take you to the Oscars. ■

GOLDEN HOUR

*2026 HAS BEEN A STANDOUT YEAR FOR INDEPENDENT CINEMA FROM THE **NORTHEAST***



SHAPE OF MOMO *(Sikkim)*

Tribeny Rai's portrait of a thirty-something woman adjusting to the patriarchal ways of her hometown won the Grand Jury Prize at the Seattle International Film Festival, alongside critical acclaim on its release in India in May



VILLAGE ROCKSTARS 2 *(Assam)*

Rima Das's follow-up to her National Award-winning film won an award in Busan (2024) and screened at the Berlin film festivals next year. Releases in cinemas here on September 25

THE ELYSIAN FIELD *(Meghalaya)*



Pradip Kurbah's Khasi film has been a festival darling, winning awards abroad and back in India. Set in Khasi Hills in 2047, it follows six villagers grapple with loss and loneliness



BOONG *(Manipur)*

Manipuri cinema found a place on the global stage after Lakshmipriya Devi's feature debut following a kid in search of his father won the prestigious BAFTA award for the Best Children's & Family Film in February